



Class apart: (From left) Devendra Jhajharia, Mariyappan Thangavelu, Deepa Malik, Sachin Tendulkar and Varun Singh Bhati during a felicitation programme. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

There was a time when Mariyappan's fights on the field were intertwined with his battles off it — like seeking sustenance as an athlete, financial stability, and eventually gaining recognition. Now, he has the luxury of focusing solely on pursuing excellence, a privilege that has claimed plenty of blood, sweat, and tears in return.

Coming full circle

Mariyappan's blooming career coincided with the twilight of another para-athlete, veteran javelin thrower Devendra Jhajharia. The three-time medallist made headlines when he won gold at the 2004 Athens Paralympics with a world-record throw of 62.15m.

When Jhajharia, now retired and at the helm of the Paralympic

Committee of India (PCI), overcame the physical and mental toll of an arm amputation and found his calling in sports, naysayers quickly tried to gate-keep the space for able-bodied athletes.

"When I picked up the javelin and went to the ground to train, people would ask me, '*Kya kaam hai tera yahan?*' (What are you here for?)" Jhajharia recalls.

"Now, they ask, '*Aapko Sumit Antil banna hai? Navdeep banna hai? Devendra Jhajharia banna hai?*' [Do you want to be Sumit Antil? Navdeep? Devendra Jhajharia?] Life has come full circle," he beams.

Para sports in India currently finds itself in an interesting phase. Team India returned from Paris with an impressive 29-medal haul, its best-ever performance in a single edition, surpassing the previous record at the 2021 Tokyo Games by 10 medals. For those who have followed and supported the Paralympic movement in India, including Jhajharia himself, this was a moment of validation.

"Before heading to Paris, in the lead-up to our departure, I said we would win at least 25 medals. One of the reporters there asked — 'Isn't this a bit overconfident?'"

He replied. "This isn't overconfidence; it's experience."

His predecessor, Deepa Malik — a Paralympic silver medallist from Rio who is now the South Asia representative to the Asian Olympic Council — echoes this sentiment and doubly underlines the systemic changes over the past decade that have boosted India's performance from just one medal in 2012 to 29 this year.

"The growth of para sports in India is directly linked to policy changes toward this sector and a shift from viewing the Paralympic Committee of India as an NGO to a full-fledged federation," she tells *Sportstar*.

"Earlier, for tournaments, there used to be this casual attitude of '*kisi ko bhi bhej do*' (just send anyone randomly). Now, there's much more accountability for every single